SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

ASSESING THE LEVEL OF HUMAN RIGHTS AWARENESS AND UNDERSTANDING AMONG POLICE OFFICER: IMPLICATIONS FOR RIGHT-BASED LAW ENFORCEMENT

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

Background of the study

Human rights are the fundamental freedoms inherent to every individual, ensuring dignity, equality, and justice regardless of race, gender, nationality, or religion, yet in the Philippine context these rights are continually threatened by recurring issues of police misconduct and alleged abuses. One major problem facing police officers today is their limited understanding and inconsistent interpretation of human rights standards, which can contribute to rights violations during law enforcement operations and undermine the practice of rights-based policing (Martin, 2022).

Globally, policing is increasingly assessed not only by crime reduction but by how consistently it upholds human dignity in international norms such as the UN Code of Conduct for Law Enforcement Officials, which emphasizes respect for human rights, and the UN Basic Principles on the Use of Force and Firearms, which require legality, necessity, proportionality, and accountability. While these frameworks set clear standards, practice often falls short under operational pressures, underscoring the importance of assessing officers' knowledge, attitudes, and application of human rights as a critical measure of legitimacy and trust in policing (OHCHR, 2024).

In the Philippines, A police again appear responsible for the fatal beating of a man in their custody. Videos of the incident, which went viral, allegedly show Police Staff Sergeant Ronald Gamayon of the Southern Leyte provincial police beating Gilbert Ranes with his bare hands on a busy street in Maasin City. Ranes, a resident of nearby Macrohon town, was declared dead after being taken to the hospital (Conde, 2022).

The United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) provides a comprehensive guide for police officers emphasizing the importance of internalizing human rights principles, reporting violations, and maintaining professional conduct through ethical codes aligned with international standards.

The guide stresses more on Human Rights-Based Policing (2023), promoting democratic governance and respect for human dignity it advocates for strict adherence to police policies, international human rights norms, and professional competence to prevent violations, highlighting the need to institutionalize human rights principles across all operational levels of the police (PNP Guidebook, 2013). Despite these efforts, assessments reveal persistent human rights violations such as extrajudicial killings and arbitrary arrests that undermine the credibility of reforms, as documented by international organizations Ntizoyimana et al., (2025).

Amnesty International Philippines (2025), Research gaps remain, particularly in empirical evidence on how human rights training impacts actual police behavior and community relations, as well as limited evaluation of internal accountability systems and the sociocultural factors influencing police attitudes. Addressing these gaps is essential for strengthening rights-based law enforcement reforms and enhancing oversight mechanisms to reduce ongoing abuses effectively.

One such relevant study of Banatao et al., (2024), Who assessed the implementation of the Philippine National Police Human Rights Development Program, highlighting the need to

close gaps in human rights knowledge and improve police accountability through education and institutional reforms. Additionally, the United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (2020), emphasizes the critical importance of assessing police understanding of human rights to promote compliance and address effectively.

Assessing the level of human rights awareness and understanding among police officers is fundamentally significant for promoting accountability, protecting citizens' rights, and enhancing public trust in law enforcement. (Macabeo, 2022) emphasizes that such assessments reveal gaps in the Philippine National Police's (PNP) Human Rights Development Program, guiding necessary improvements in training, policy enforcement, and community collaboration, thereby strengthening the human rights culture within police operations and aligning police conduct with national laws and international standards. The study highlights the vital link between human rights awareness and the prevention of abuse, contributing to safer and more just communities. Furthermore, the (PNP Guidebook on Human Rights-Based Policing, 2013) underscores that integrating human rights principles into policing strategies fosters respect, dignity, and lawful conduct, with human rights education and institutional reforms being crucial for ethical behavior, professional competence, and support for democratic governance and the rule of law. This research is essential for informing policy and operational reforms that enhance accountability mechanisms and police-community relations in the Philippines. zAccording to PNP Human Rights Affairs Office (HRAO) Director Chief Superintendent Dennis Siervo (2017), the cases faced by the 56 police officers who were complained against for human rights violations include homicide and illegal arrest. However, he said that they are not yet certain whether these cases are related to illegal drugs, even though the incidents happened during the height of the PNP's war on drugs campaign. Siervo also stated that they will recommend to the

Commission on Human Rights (CHR) that the complaints against the 56 police officers who committed human rights violations be filed in court.

Review of Related Literature

Police officers operate at the frontline where social conditions intersect with legal norms, making their comprehension of human rights essential for the fair and just exercise of their duties. Human rights in policing are framed not merely as external legal obligations but as emergent from the everyday sensemaking processes of officers, influenced by organizational culture, training, and individual experiences (Martin, 2022).

Based on the Philippine National Police Guidebook on Human Rights-Based Policing (2013), There are Ten (10) International Human Rights Standards for Law Enforcement these are Equal Protection, Respectful Treatment, Use of Force, Policing Non-Violent Assemblies, Use of Lethal Force, Arresting Persons on Legal Grounds, Detainees' Rights, Humane Treatment of Detainees, Refusal to Obey Unjust Orders, Reporting Violations. The purpose of this guidebook is to guide every police officer in performing their duties while upholding the dignity, rights, and freedom of all individuals. The guidebook provides practical guidelines and training for officers to apply human rights principles in their daily duties. Overall, it helps build a more ethical, transparent and people centered police organization.

The study explores how certain demographic and professional characteristics specifically age, gender, years of service, and rank or position, influence the level of awareness, perception, and application of human rights among police officers. In contrast, older officers may rely more on traditional policing approaches. Gender also contributes to differences in human rights awareness, as UN Women and UNODC (2020), reported that female police officers often demonstrate greater empathy and restraint, particularly when dealing with vulnerable individuals. Moreover , DeJong (2022) noted that officers with longer years of service often

develop broader experience and discretion in handling rights-sensitive cases, although they may also face the risk of desensitization due to routine exposure to stressful policing situations.

Furthermore, rank influences how officers perceive and implement human rights standards within their organizations. Higher-ranking officers typically possess the authority to influence institutional norms and training priorities. (Moore, 2023), emphasized that leadership grounded in human rights principles promotes accountability and ethical conduct across police ranks. Conversely, when leaders prioritize control and punishment over rights-based practices, such attitudes can trickle down the hierarchy, affecting the entire organization's culture. Thus, examining rank is crucial in understanding how organizational structure and leadership dynamics shape the implementation of human rights principles in law enforcement agencies. The dependent variables—equal protection, respectful treatment, use of force, policing non-violent assemblies, use of lethal force, arresting persons on legal grounds, detainees' rights, humane treatment of detainees, refusal to obey unjust orders, and reporting violations—represent the main aspects of rights-based policing.

According to Amnesty International (2021), these dimensions reflect the fundamental obligations of law enforcement to protect human dignity while maintaining order. Police officers must ensure that their actions are guided by fairness, legality, and accountability. Failure to observe these principles can result in violations that undermine public trust and the legitimacy of law enforcement agencies.

Related Literature

Police officers are often the first representatives of the state to engage with citizens; thus, their understanding of human rights directly affects how justice is experienced by individuals in society. Human Rights Watch (2020) further explains that police awareness of rights principles

such as equality before the law, humane treatment, and lawful arrest helps prevent abuse of power and enhances community trust. In countries that implement rights-based policing frameworks, officers who are well-trained in human rights show higher compliance with ethical and procedural standards.

According to Skinns (2020), conducted a study on detainee experiences in police custody and found that the perception of fairness and dignity largely depended on how officers treated them. The research connected rank and position to the ability of officers to foster a humane environment, showing that leaders who prioritize dignity-based practices significantly reduce abuses in detention settings. This supports the idea that higher-ranking officers influence the overall culture of respectful treatment and humane detainee handling. In addition, Sheppard (2024) revealed that female officers are less likely to employ force in confrontational situations compared to their male counterparts. Moreover, the relationship between gender and operational restraint, directly linking it to use of force and policing non-violent assemblies. These results support global findings that gender diversity improves communication-based approaches, reducing unnecessary

aggression in policing.

Cubitt et al., (2022), investigated patterns of police misconduct and concluded that gender, tenure, and rank significantly influence an officer's likelihood of engaging in unethical behavior. Longer years of service and higher rank were associated with decreased accountability when not paired with ethical oversight. Furthermore, the findings relate to use of lethal force, unlawful arrests, and failure to report violations, emphasizing the need for stronger supervision and institutional checks in law enforcement. Duret (2024), research on police whistleblowers highlighted that organizational culture and fear of retaliation discourage officers from reporting

misconduct. This directly relates rank or position and institutional climate to the dependent variables reporting violations and refusal to obey unjust orders. Moreover, the study reinforces that ethical leadership is critical in protecting those who speak out against rights violations. In addition, Alleweldt (2024) emphasized that training and professional experience play a vital role in shaping humane policing practices. Officers with longer years of service and repeated exposure to rights-based training were found to handle detainees with greater respect for legal and ethical standards, reinforcing the link between experience and humane treatment.

In addition, (Dobson, 2024) consistently demonstrate that individual characteristics such as age, gender, and service experience affect decision-making during encounters. Younger and less-experienced officers tend to over-rely on physical force, while seasoned officers with adequate rights training exercise restraint. These findings tie directly to the dependent variables use of force, use of lethal force, and policing non-violent assemblies, showing that demographic and experiential variables deeply influence rights-based policing outcomes.

Age

A growing body of literature underscores the importance of age in shaping police officers' awareness, understanding, and observance of human rights. Research by Rocha-Jiménez et al., (2019) In the SHIELD study found that younger police officers, particularly female officers, were less likely to engage in rights-violating practices such as arbitrary searches or syringe confiscations, suggesting that younger officer are more responsive to rights-based training.

Engel et al., (2020) examined the impact of de-escalation and crisis intervention training in the Louisville Metro Police Department and found that younger cohorts were more adaptable to human-rights-oriented strategies, demonstrating more significant behavioral change after

training compared to older officers. This highlights how age influences the learning uptake and application of rights principles in operational settings.

Additionally, Martin (2022), conducted qualitative interviews with British police officers and found that younger officers tend to interpret human rights as practical, situation-based decisions rather than abstract legal doctrines, while older officers rely more on traditional enforcement practices.

Student officers on the Police Constable Degree Apprenticeship (PCDA) report a disconnect between their academic learning and practical policing, while veteran officers often resist new technologies and procedural reforms aimed at enhancing transparency and human-rights accountability Pepper et al., (2022).

In a related study, the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (2022), reported that the effectiveness of rights-based police training varies by cohort, with younger officers displaying higher post-training retention and behavioral change.

Gender

These behavioral differences suggest that gender plays a meaningful role in shaping how human rights are interpreted and upheld within police institutions. According to UN Women and UNODC (2021), integrating gender-sensitive training and increasing the representation of women in police forces enhances the overall human rights performance of law enforcement agencies. Thus, understanding gender-based differences is critical for developing more inclusive, fair, and rights-based policing practices. By examining gender as an independent variable, this study seeks to uncover whether these patterns are evident within the current practices of police officers and how they may inform institutional reforms for a more equitable justice system.

Research by Vasko (2024) emphasizes the importance of gender diversity in policing, highlighting how female officers tend to adopt a more compassionate and supportive approach towards victims, particularly in sensitive cases such as sexual assault. This approach fosters trust and cooperation between law enforcement and the community, contributing to rights-based law enforcement. In addition, Boehme et al., (2022), found that female officers are less prone to using physical force and more inclined towards peaceful conflict resolution, which aligns with human rights principles in policing. Furthermore, Rocha-Jiménez et al., (2019), noted that female law enforcement officers (LEOs) show greater community engagement and higher rates of listening skills compared to their male counterparts, who more often resort to physical force. This behavioral difference has implications for occupational safety and public health, reinforcing the positive impact of gender-inclusive policing strategies.

Angehrn et al., (2021) discusses how gender influences police occupational experiences, noting that female officers often face gendered assignment biases but are more involved in cases requiring empathy and advocacy for victims' rights. Female officers' ability to handle sensitive gender-based cases, such as those involving women and children, is also supported by studies like the one by the International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Sciences (2024), highlighting their critical role in respecting victims' dignity and privacy.

In addition, gender disparities and biases within law enforcement agencies present significant challenges that hinder the full realization of rights-based policing. One of the most critical issues is the underrepresentation of women in policing, particularly in Southeast Asia and the Philippines, where female officers are often confined to desk jobs or support roles, limiting their influence on operational decisions and policy-making (UNODC, UN Women & INTERPOL,

2020). As a result, the valuable perspectives and approaches that female officers bring to human rights issues are frequently overlooked.

Cabilan et al., (2023), also reported that female officers in the Philippines face systemic barriers such as discrimination and lack of operational opportunities, affecting their morale and limiting their potential contributions to human rights-focused policing. These challenges illustrate that gender inequality within police institutions can negatively impact the implementation of human rights policies, and addressing these disparities is essential for achieving a truly rights-based law enforcement system.

In the Philippines, UN Women and UNODC (2019) documented the launch of gendersensitive policing practices in anti-human trafficking operations, revealing that law enforcement strategies that incorporate a gender perspective not only improve case outcomes but also enhance trust in police institutions. Andrea (2024), highlighted the positive impact of gender-sensitive training in Colombia, noting that such programs improved officers' responses to domestic violence by reinforcing respect for victims' rights.

Years of Service

According to Jeffries (2021), officers with longer years of service demonstrate higher levels of empathy and moral reasoning in handling sensitive cases such as domestic violence. This empathy reflects a more profound internalization of human rights values, suggesting that accumulated experience strengthens officers' capacity to act with compassion and fairness. Furthermore, Lin et al., (2023), in a longitudinal study on police education and democratic policing in Taiwan, found that extended years of service contribute positively to officers' understanding of moral reasoning and human rights. The study emphasized that exposure to

diverse social situations throughout an officer's career deepens awareness of ethical policing and reinforces respect for human dignity.

The moral judgements of new recruits to the police by drawing on two stages of semistructured interviews with recruits over their first 6 months working for Lancashire Constabulary in England. Evidence is presented that many recruits bring with them an empathetic idea of policing demonstrating compassion for others, whether those others are colleagues, victims, suspects or anyone else who comes into contact with the police. New officers often enter the profession with a high degree of enthusiasm for rights-based policing, demonstrating openness to reform and ethical engagement with communities. However, their understanding of human rights is primarily theoretical and may still be influenced by organizational culture and field pressures (Millie & Hirschler, 2023).

According to (Helfers & Nhan, 2022), investigating police officers' lived experiences during the COVID-19 pandemic noted that officers with many years of service described their roles in terms of past crisis frameworks and drew on older models of enforcement rather than newer rights-informed community-engagement models.

(Gonzaga, 2024), a study of human-rights standards practiced by law-enforcement officers reports demographic profiles including years of service but stops short of full regression analysis; however it suggests that officers with longer service may report different understandings of rights standards than newer officers.

Rank

Studies show that police rank affects access to leadership and ethics professional development: higher-ranking officers are more likely to attend command/leadership courses that

include modules on ethical leadership, community relations, and rights-based policing, which in turn strengthen their competence in upholding fairness, equality, and justice Signori et al., (2023). According to Maskály et al., (2021), police leaders who demonstrate ethical integrity and transparency foster greater awareness of human-rights principles among their subordinates. Their studies emphasize that leadership behavior directly shapes officers' attitudes toward fairness, equality, and public accountability in law-enforcement operations.

Ossei-Owusu (2021), explained that police organizations often employ formal and informal quota systems that pressure officers to achieve numerical targets such as arrests or citations, which can distort discretion and undermine due process. These pressures are often passed down the chain of command, where higher-ranking officers or supervisors set performance expectations that influence the behavior of their subordinates.

Supervisors may need to be trained on how to effectively conduct daily observations and audits of what officers are doing, including training on the right inquiries that will help them determine what officers are doing (NASEM, 2021). National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine 2022. Policies and Practices to Minimize Police Use of Force Internationally. Washington, DC: The National Academies Press.

In high-audience and high-risk situations, participants described practices conceptualized as 'doing rank'. These practices strongly reflect the rank hierarchy and interactions between senior and junior officers adhere to the 'etiquette' of rank. In these situations, decision making is rank-based, the structure of rank provides a clear demarcation of responsibilities and the authority of rank is more explicitly utilized (Davis, 2023).

Equal Protection

Everyone is entitled to equal protection of the law, without discrimination on any grounds, and especially against violence and other threats. Be especially vigilant to protect potentially vulnerable groups such as children, the elderly, women, refugees, displaced persons, and members of minority groups (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

According to Villegas (2023), highlights that police officers who recognize and apply the concept of equal protection are better able to balance enforcement duties with the ethical imperatives of justice and equality. The neglect of this principle often results in rights violations and the erosion of public confidence in the police institution. Therefore, embedding awareness of equal protection in police education, training, and evaluation processes not only strengthens adherence to the rule of law but also transforms the PNP into a truly rights-based organization capable of protecting all citizens equally.

According to Walker and Archbold (2020), equal protection refers to the obligation of law enforcement agencies to ensure that all citizens are treated equally and that policing practices do not result in arbitrary discrimination or unequal enforcement of the law. Furthermore, Headley (2021), found that implementing anti-bias training, body-worn cameras, and community review boards are effective strategies for promoting equal protection in modern policing. National Institute for Justice, (2023), highlighted that enforcing equal protection standards in policy and practice leads to fewer complaints of discrimination, greater transparency, and improved community-police relations.

According to Davidio & Solomon (2025), disparities in policing outcomes—such as stopand search rates, arrests, and use of force—are often rooted in implicit racial bias and historical inequities that continue to shape police culture and decision-making. Additionally,

(Camp, 2023) observed that these disparities are not merely the result of individual prejudice but stem from structural practices that normalize unequal enforcement of laws. Racial disparities in policing are profound and accompanied by equally persistent gaps in trust. Analyses of these and other racial inequities are often bifurcated between institutional and individual levels of analysis. Tapp et al., (2022), reported that minority communities, particularly Black and Latino populations, remain disproportionately subjected to police scrutiny, even in cases where crime rates do not justify such attention. This creates a cycle of mistrust between law enforcement and marginalized communities.

(Mutua, 2022), noted that political pressures and inadequate leadership support often discourage officers from reporting or challenging discriminatory practices within their departments. This silence perpetuates institutional inequality and discourages reform minded policing. Furthermore, (Wong, 2024), emphasized that insufficient community involvement in policy development results in practices that fail to reflect the needs and values of diverse populations. Collectively, these challenges illustrate that the problem of ensuring equal protection is not limited to officer behavior but is deeply rooted in systemic, organizational, and societal structures that require broad, sustained reform.

Respectful Treatment

Treat all citizens and victims of crime with compassion and respect, with utmost consideration for their need for safety and privacy. It must be remembered that under the law, all arrested persons and detainees are still considered innocent and have the right to due process. Only the court can determine their guilt or innocence. Even when they are already convicted by the court, they still have the right to be treated humanely, with full respect and dignity (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

According to Higareda et al., (2024), respectful policing practices strengthen citizens' perception of justice and contribute to voluntary law compliance, a foundation for effective and democratic law enforcement. Moreover, (Espartero 2023), emphasized that treating individuals respectfully during police encounters—whether in checkpoints, arrests, or questioning—reduces incidents of aggression and increases cooperation between the police and the community. In the context of rights-based law enforcement, respect is not simply an act of courtesy but an operational principle that reinforces every person's inherent dignity as enshrined in the Philippine Constitution and international human-rights instruments. Without such awareness, law enforcement risks fostering a culture of impunity and public mistrust that weakens institutional legitimacy.

The practice of respectful treatment aligns with the modern framework of procedural justice, which posits that citizens' acceptance of police authority depends on how fairly and respectfully they are treated. Studies by Ortega, et al., (2021), found that citizens who perceive officers as respectful are more likely to view the PNP as credible and law-abiding, leading to improved police-community relations and reduced conflict. Tyler (2020), highlighted that respectful treatment enhances procedural justice, which strengthens citizens' perception of fairness and institutional trust.

Mitchell (2023), officers who communicate respectfully during encounters significantly reduce hostility and conflict, particularly in tense community or protest situations. Community policing is an operational approach to enhance the relationship between law enforcement agencies and their communities to diminish criminal activity. The Nigerian Police Force's dedication to community policing, as delineated in its strategic plans, highlights the imperative of establishing robust collaborations with communities to enhance security and law enforcement

results. Community policing is a collaborative approach wherein law enforcement agencies actively engage with the community to identify and address crime-related issues jointly. The efficacy of this approach in crime reduction has been demonstrated in several nations; nevertheless, its adoption and implementation in Nigeria remain limited.

Respectful treatment is fundamental to policing because it defines how officers exercise authority while upholding the dignity and rights of all individuals. Moreover, Donner et al., (2021), officers who consistently demonstrate respectful behavior enhance procedural fairness and reinforce public confidence in law enforcement institutions. When citizens feel respected during police encounters, they are more likely to cooperate and view policing as legitimate and just.

According to Orosco (2022), when police use empathetic language and maintain a calm demeanor, they minimize conflict escalation and foster mutual understanding. Furthermore, VAVOULA et al., (2022), observed that when respect is central to police culture, officers demonstrate greater empathy and self-restraint, which leads to fewer complaints and improved community relations. Thus, respectful treatment is not only a reflection of individual professionalism but also a structural necessity that sustains effective, ethical, and human rights–based policing in modern societies.

According to Levin (2023), found that disrespectful communication—such as verbal aggression, dismissiveness, or bias—negatively influences citizens' willingness to cooperate and comply with the law. One of the main problems lies in the gap between policy and practice while most police departments have codes of ethics emphasizing dignity and respect, real-world encounters often reflect control-oriented behavior rather than empathy or fairness.

In many instances, citizens—especially those from marginalized or minority groups—report feeling humiliated or profiled during police interactions, eroding confidence in law enforcement institutions. Communities marginalized because of racism, heterosexism, and other systems of oppression in New York City (NYC), and other large urban areas in the United States (US), have experienced a long history of aggressive policing. Thompson et al., (2021).

In addition, another recurring problem is the organizational and cultural barriers within law enforcement agencies that discourage respectful behavior. Studies by Schade & Thielgen (2025), indicate that hierarchical structures and authoritarian management styles often create environments where officers feel pressured to assert dominance rather than build rapport. Supervía et al., (2020), reported that high workloads, emotional exhaustion, and exposure to aggression can lead to irritability and reduced emotional regulation, making it difficult for officers to remain courteous under stress. The absence of consistent accountability mechanisms further exacerbates this issue, as disrespectful conduct often goes unaddressed or normalized within the organization. Consequently, the problem of disrespectful treatment reflects not only individual officer behavior but also deeper systemic issues in police culture, training, and institutional oversight.

Use of Force

Do not use force except when strictly necessary and to the minimum extent required under the circumstances (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013). White and Fradella (2020), use of force refers to the amount and type of effort a police officer employs to compel compliance by an unwilling subject in a lawful situation.

According to Navarro (2023), the misuse of force by law enforcement officers not only violates individual rights but also erodes public confidence in the justice system, leading to

diminished cooperation and legitimacy. The PNP Human Rights Affairs Office (2022) reiterated that awareness of lawful use of force enables officers to respond effectively to threats while safeguarding human dignity and the right to life. Furthermore, awareness of the use of force principle strengthens accountability and procedural justice, which are central to rights-based law enforcement, found that officers who received human-rights education and de-escalation training demonstrated greater control and situational judgment, leading to fewer cases of misconduct and civilian harm Lavoie et al., (2023).

Bgen & Crame (2021), argued that force awareness enhances police decision-making, particularly in high-risk encounters, by emphasizing negotiation, restraint, and non-lethal interventions. In addition, Tondo et al., (2020), noted that understanding proportionality and necessity in force application supports community-oriented policing, as citizens are more likely to respect and cooperate with officers who act with fairness and restraint. Awareness, therefore, is not limited to compliance with regulations—it shapes the moral compass of policing, ensuring that the PNP operates as both a protector of public order and a defender of human rights.

The U.S. Department of Justice (2025) emphasized that understanding and appropriately applying the use of force enhances officer confidence in high-risk situations, allowing them to respond effectively without resorting to excessive measures. Research by Wood et al., (2020), further highlights that structured force policies, when aligned with procedural justice, increase public trust and reduce violent confrontations. Thus, the use of force, when exercised within ethical and legal boundaries, is indispensable for effective policing and community safety. Moreover, Engel et al., (2022), found that departments emphasizing de-escalation and tactical restraint reduce the frequency and severity of force incidents while maintaining officer safety. United Nations Human Rights Council (2024), noted that adherence to international standards—

such as necessity, proportionality, and precaution—helps align police practices with democratic and humanitarian principles. Therefore, the responsible and judicious use of force is vital not only for maintaining security but also for fostering legitimacy, professionalism, and respect for the rule of law in contemporary policing.

According to Brown (2025), many incidents involving excessive force stem from inadequate training in threat assessment and emotional regulation, leading officers to resort to physical measures prematurely. Novak (2024), found that disparities in force occur disproportionately across racial and socioeconomic groups, raising public concern about discrimination and accountability. The absence of standardized reporting systems across police departments further complicates data collection and oversight, making it difficult to identify patterns of misconduct Güss et al., (2020).

Triola & Chanin (2023), revealed that internal investigations into force incidents frequently lack transparency, and disciplinary measures are inconsistently applied, allowing problematic behavior to persist. International Crisis Group (2024), also reported that inadequate mental health support and burnout among officers exacerbate reactive decision-making, increasing the likelihood of unnecessary force. These systemic and organizational deficiencies highlight that the problem of use of force is not merely a matter of individual misconduct but a reflection of deeper institutional failures that require cultural, policy, and leadership reforms to ensure ethical and proportionate policing.

Policing Non-Violent Assemblies

Avoid using force when policing unlawful but non-violent assemblies. When dispersing violent assemblies, use force only to the minimum extent necessary (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

According to Santos (2023), human-rights–based policing requires officers to view assemblies as legitimate forms of civic participation rather than potential threats to order. Mead (2021), emphasize that most demonstrations are peaceful and that facilitative, dialogue-oriented approaches—grounded in crowd psychology, communication, and respect for assembly rights—produce better safety and legitimacy outcomes than coercive, containment-first strategies.

Garcia et al., (2021), emphasized that police awareness of lawful crowd management fosters peaceful engagement and prevents unnecessary escalation of tension between law enforcement and protesters. This information can be used in order to enhance many sectors involved in city activity such as transport, energy or health. Crowd-sourcing initiatives focus their efforts on making cities safer places that are adapted to the population size they host. In this way, citizens are able to report the issues they identify to the relevant body so that they can be fixed and, at the same time, they can provide useful information to other citizens.

United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (2025), argued that a lack of awareness about lawful assembly rights often results in excessive force, arbitrary arrests, and suppression of free speech—actions that erode public trust and undermine the rule of law. Further noted that integrating non-violent assembly protocols into police education fosters accountability, professionalism, and respect for civil liberties. When police officers are equipped with a rightsbased approach, they can better distinguish between peaceful and unlawful conduct, ensuring that policing decisions remain proportionate and lawful (UNODC, 2020).

Maguire & Oakley (2020), emphasized that officers who are trained in human rights–centered policing contribute to greater institutional legitimacy and community cooperation, which are essential for maintaining peace and preventing escalation during public gatherings.

Thus, the importance of this variable lies in its direct connection to professional competence, ethical responsibility, and the credibility of law enforcement institutions.

Recent studies have shown that police officers' attitudes and behavior during peaceful demonstrations serve as indicators of how deeply human rights principles are integrated into policing practice. Officers who understand and respect the right to peaceful assembly help foster a culture of transparency and restraint, which strengthens community trust and democratic governance. Conversely, the absence of such understanding often leads to human rights violations, public mistrust, and reputational damage to law enforcement agencies (OSCE, 2025).

Lin (2024), further noted that human rights awareness among police officers enhances their decision-making capacity in tense protest situations, reducing the likelihood of escalation and social unrest. Therefore, integrating the principles of non-violent assembly policing into police education, policy, and practice is vital not only for protecting civil liberties but also for reinforcing ethical, accountable, and effective law enforcement.

United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (2020), further describes peaceful assemblies as fundamental human rights that encompass demonstrations, processions, strikes, and rallies aimed at expressing collective concerns or aspirations. Within this framework, policing nonviolent assemblies entails law enforcement practices that prioritize facilitation, communication, proportionality, and respect for human rights standards. This variable therefore measures how police officers understand and apply rights-based approaches in handling peaceful protests— balancing order maintenance with the protection of democratic freedoms.

The problem in policing non-violent assemblies has persisted despite the growing adoption of human rights frameworks in law enforcement training and policy. Recent studies reveal that police officers often lack adequate understanding of the principles of proportionality,

legality, and necessity when managing peaceful demonstrations, resulting in the excessive use of force and rights violations Tsai et al., (2024). Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe (2021), reported that in many democratic and developing countries, police responses to non-violent gatherings remain rooted in control-oriented tactics rather than facilitative approaches.

Moreover, Recent empirical and comparative research also highlights how political pressures, organizational culture, and inadequate training systems exacerbate the problem of policing non-violent assemblies. Johansson (2023), found that militarized crowd-control strategies heighten social tension and psychological trauma among protesters, further eroding the legitimacy of the police. Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights (2023), observed that the lack of human rights–based training continues to impede police officers' capacity to protect, rather than restrict, peaceful assemblies.

Use of Lethal Force

Lethal force should not be used except when strictly unavoidable to protect your life or the lives of others (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

Lethal force refers to the intentional use of deadly means by police officers to protect life in situations of extreme danger. According to Philippine National Police (PNP, 2013), lethal force must never be used except when it is strictly unavoidable to protect one's life or the life of others. This aligns with the international human rights principle that police should always act with legality, necessity, and proportionality. The PNP Guidebook on Human Rights-Based Policing explains that officers are morally and legally obligated to exhaust all peaceful options before resorting to firearms. The document further stresses that human rights awareness should be embedded in police training and everyday practice.

According to Kreuzer et al., (2023), the use of deadly force by law enforcement in countries like the Philippines and Brazil often reflects not only individual decision-making but also the broader institutional and cultural contexts. Their research shows that when police officers operate under political pressure or unclear operational guidelines, they are more likely to use excessive or unlawful force. The study highlights that internal accountability systems and transparent investigations play a crucial role in shaping when and how lethal force is applied. This means that reducing police violence requires more than just rules—it demands consistent enforcement and oversight.

In another study, Stenshol, K. (2024), found that decision-making during police operations often depends on the officer's training and ability to manage stress. The study observed that officers who underwent scenario-based simulations that focused on de-escalation and communication were less likely to choose lethal options in high-pressure situations. This demonstrates that proper training helps officers to evaluate threats more accurately and respond proportionally. Training in crisis intervention and mental preparedness enhances judgment and promotes restraint, reducing unnecessary loss of life.

Meanwhile, Amnesty International (2021), emphasized that many reported cases of unlawful killings stem from poor understanding of the limits of police power and the lack of effective oversight. The organization explained that misuse of lethal force is often linked to a culture of impunity where officers are rarely held accountable for excessive actions. Amnesty further stated that governments must strengthen internal disciplinary systems, ensure independent investigations, and promote transparency to restore public confidence in law enforcement. This approach ensures that lethal force remains a last resort rather than a habitual response.

Moreover, PolicingLaw.info (2025), reported that although the Philippines has legal frameworks regulating police use of force, enforcement remains inconsistent. The report found that while policies follow international standards, gaps persist in actual practice due to weak oversight and limited resources. The absence of independent review mechanisms often leads to a lack of accountability, allowing abuses to go unpunished. To address this, continuous review of operational procedures, public reporting, and institutional reforms are needed to ensure that the use of lethal force strictly adheres to human rights standards.

Arresting Persons on Legal Grounds

Arresting persons on legal grounds is one of the fundamental duties of police officers and a key measure of how well they uphold constitutional rights and the rule of law. According to the Philippine National Police (2021), in its Revised Police Operational Procedures Manual, arrests must be performed only when lawful grounds exist, and every process must comply with prescribed legal safeguards. This policy ensures that no person is deprived of liberty without due process and highlights the police's obligation to uphold human dignity in all law enforcement operations. The manual further stresses that the authority to arrest carries both legal and ethical responsibilities, requiring officers to act with fairness and integrity.

The Commission on Human Rights (2023), reported that many rights violations in the Philippines stem from unlawful or arbitrary arrests resulting from weak procedural awareness and limited supervision. Similarly, Aguila (2024), found that police officers who clearly understand constitutional provisions on arrest procedures are more capable of balancing public safety with individual rights. By improving their grasp of legal processes, officers are less likely to engage in unlawful detention, thereby enhancing public confidence in law enforcement institutions.

Awareness of lawful arrest procedures thus plays a vital role in strengthening the legitimacy of policing practices in the country.

Empirical findings also show that continuous legal education and training significantly reduce unlawful arrests. Pastrana (2024) discovered that officers who regularly undergo mandatory PNP training programs demonstrate better procedural compliance and accountability during arrest operations. Galabin et al., (2021), also noted that community-oriented policing initiatives that emphasize legality and ethics promote respect for human rights and help prevent misuse of police authority. These studies underline the importance of institutional training programs that integrate legal frameworks with practical policing strategies to ensure every arrest conforms to lawful standards.

In addition, Modise (2023), in his study Procedural Justice: Rebuilding Public Trust in Policing to Enhance Community Relations, emphasized that lawful and respectful arrest practices directly influence citizens' trust in the police. He explained that procedural justice — characterized by fairness, transparency, and accountability — strengthens the moral legitimacy of law enforcement. When officers conduct arrests with respect and legal justification, the public perceives them as trustworthy, cooperative, and just. Therefore, maintaining procedural fairness during arrests not only protects the rights of individuals but also enhances police-community relations and social order.

Furthermore, Floresca (2024) explored the experiences of police trainees in field training and found that exposure to realistic operational environments helps improve officers' understanding of lawful arrest procedures. The study revealed that trainees who receive mentorship and procedural guidance are better prepared to make sound legal judgments during field operations. This suggests that effective supervision, experiential learning, and institutional

oversight are essential in developing officers who are both competent and legally compliant. Together, these insights demonstrate that lawful arrests rely not only on established legal frameworks but also on continuous training and ethical awareness among police personnel. guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

The Center for Justice and Accountability (2023), explains that arbitrary detention—detention without lawful justification or due process—constitutes a grave violation of international norms, undermining both the rule of law and human dignity. These foundational principles establish that detaining authorities must always act under clear legal mandates, and any deprivation of liberty must be justified, necessary, and lawful to prevent abuse of state power.

Beyond the legality of detention, international law guarantees procedural safeguards that ensure fairness and accountability in every stage of detention. The Human Rights Library at the University of Minnesota outlines that detainees must be informed promptly of the reasons for their arrest, allowed to contact legal counsel, and brought before a judge without undue delay University of Minnesota Human Rights Library (2020). These safeguards, reiterated in the Handbook on Human Rights and Arrest, Pre-Trial Detention and Administration of Justice, emphasize that procedural guarantees such as access to legal aid and timely judicial review prevent arbitrary detention and protect detainees from abuse or prolonged confinement without trial Collectively, these measures ensure that individuals deprived of liberty still retain the right to fair and humane treatment under due process.

The humane treatment of detainees, meanwhile, extends to the physical and psychological conditions under which they are held. According to the Australian Human Rights Commission, all persons deprived of liberty must be treated with humanity and respect for their inherent dignity,

and detention should never impose suffering beyond what is necessary for lawful custody Attorney-General's Department (2022). Research published in the National Library of Medicine reinforces this by discussing the "principle of equivalence," which demands that detainees receive the same standard of health care available to the general population Groenewegen et al., (2022). These studies highlight that humane treatment not only protects detainees' rights but also strengthens the moral legitimacy of law enforcement institutions, reflecting the ethical responsibility of the state to ensure dignity and fairness even for those deprived of liberty.

Additionally, Skinns et al., (2020), emphasized that detainees' perceptions of fairness and legitimacy largely depend on how they are treated while in custody, linking humane treatment to procedural justice and ethical policing. In her study "'Treat Them as a Human Being': Dignity in Police Detention", she argued that detainees' dignity is shaped not merely by policy but by the everyday interactions between police officers and those in detention, and that fostering humane environments reduces custodial abuse and enhances police legitimacy. At the institutional and global level, several frameworks safeguard detainees' rights through international oversight and legal norms.

The International Committee of the Red Cross (2023), for instance, regularly monitors detention facilities worldwide to ensure that detainees are treated with dignity and fairness in compliance with international humanitarian law. Despite the existence of these international and domestic standards, gaps in implementation persist, particularly in contexts involving immigration detention and developing legal systems. A study from the University of Cincinnati Law Blog on Human Rights highlighted that conditions in for-profit immigration detention centers often fail to meet even the minimum standards for health, safety, and humane treatment, violating Article 25 of the UDHR Schwab (2024).

Detainees' Rights

Ensure that all detainees, immediately after their arrest, have access to their family and lawyer. They must also be given immediate medical assistance whenever necessary (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

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Humane Treatment of Detainees

All detainees must be treated humanely. Under any circumstances, do not inflict, instigate, nor tolerate any act of torture or ill-treatment, and refuse to obey any order to do so (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

The Commission on Human Rights of the Philippines (2022) emphasized that fostering awareness on humane treatment is essential in promoting accountability among law enforcers and preventing systemic abuses, particularly in custodial investigations and detention settings. Peyton et al., (2019), demonstrated that respectful and humane interactions between police officers and the public significantly enhance perceptions of police legitimacy and foster cooperation. This supports the notion that human rights awareness and the practice of humane treatment are vital components of rights-based law enforcement.

Weisburd et al., (2022), revealed that police officers who underwent procedural justice training, which emphasized fairness, respect, and humane treatment, were less likely to engage in coercive practices and more inclined to uphold due process, thereby promoting a more rightsbased approach to law enforcement.

Pejić (2020), emphasizes that humane treatment requires more than simply avoiding abuse; custodial authorities must ensure detainees receive adequate medical care, sufficient food, clean living conditions, and opportunities to maintain contact with their families, thereby upholding human dignity.

The Council of Europe (2022), highlighted that police officers' awareness and application of humane treatment standards not only protect detainees' dignity and rights but also enhance officers' professionalism and support the implementation of rights-based law enforcement.

Van Hall et al., (2024), found that detainees' views of fairness are strongly influenced by whether they are treated with respect, given voice, and receive clear information, underscoring how humane treatment in custodial contexts helps bolster procedural justice.

Refusal to Obey Unjust Orders

Do not carry out, order, or cover up extra-legal killings or enforced disappearance, and refuse to obey any order to do so (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013).

Monaghan (2023), emphasized that police officers have a moral and legal responsibility to exercise independent judgment and, when necessary, refuse to obey unjust or unlawful orders, especially when such directives may result in violations of human rights during law enforcement operations.

Banatao et al., (2024), found that police officers who underwent ethical-training and leadership-development initiatives exhibited significantly stronger attitudinal links to reduced misconduct, thus suggesting enhanced readiness to challenge unethical directives within the chain of command.

Mooney (2019), highlights that while many jurisdictions criminalize disobeying "lawful orders," there is often significant uncertainty about what makes an order lawful. This ambiguity can leave officers uncertain about their obligations and rights, potentially leading to unjust enforcement actions. Another challenge is the ethical dilemma officers face when ordered to perform tasks that may violate human rights. Police officers are legally and ethically obliged to distinguish between lawful and unlawful orders, and must refuse to carry out directives that are manifestly unlawful, as obedience does not excuse participation in wrongdoing.

According to Maile et al., (2022), promoting autonomy and moral judgment among law enforcement officers within professional and ethical frameworks strengthens organizational

accountability and enables officers to make principled decisions, even in high-pressure or ethically challenging situations.

According to Hadjimatheou & Nathan (2022), law enforcement officers are entrusted with moral responsibilities that sometimes necessitate the refusal of orders that are unjust or unethical, underscoring the critical role of ethical judgment in policing practices.

Custodio (2023), highlights that ethical training and a strong organizational culture equip law enforcement officers with the awareness and skills necessary to identify and resist unethical or unlawful directives, thereby promoting accountability and reducing instances of misconduct. Taniguchi et al., (2022), found that active bystander training significantly enhances police officers' confidence and ability to identify and respond to unethical practices, underscoring the importance of ethical training in promoting accountability and empowering officers to act responsibly within hierarchical structures. Collectively, these studies underscore that the refusal to obey unjust orders is both a moral duty and a professional imperative for human rights–based policing.

Reporting Violations

Report all violations of these standards to your senior officer and to the nearest Prosecutor's Office. Do everything within your ability and authority to ensure steps are taken to investigate violations of the standards (PNP guidebook on human rights-based policing, 2013). According to Rosalez (2023), awareness of reporting violations ensures that police personnel recognize their accountability not only to the law but also to the public they serve, fostering transparency and moral courage within the organization.

Westmarland & Conway (2020), emphasized that the persistence of the "blue code of silence" within police organizations is largely influenced by peer loyalty, organizational culture, and

rank, noting that officers in higher positions play a crucial role in shaping attitudes toward reporting misconduct and maintaining ethical accountability.

According to Birch et al., (2024), variations in rank or position among police officers are associated with differences in decision-making and procedural understanding, suggesting that higher-ranking officers may approach rights-based policing differently than lower-ranking personnel.

Farrow (2024), emphasized that organizational culture and the presence of clear reporting mechanisms significantly influence police officers' willingness to report misconduct. Officers are more likely to act when collective responsibility is encouraged and silence in the face of wrongdoing is discouraged.

According to Roche (2025), effective whistle-blowing laws and reporting mechanisms not only expose misconduct but also deter future violations by reinforcing institutional oversight and ethical compliance among public officials, including police officers.

Borian et al., (2024), found that leadership practices characterized by transformational and transactional styles significantly correlate with higher levels of organizational integrity in police units, suggesting that leadership influencing culture and reporting norms may be instrumental in reducing unreported misconduct.

Ivković et al., (2020), emphasized that differences in police rank influence officers' attitudes toward integrity and their willingness to report misconduct, showing that hierarchical culture plays a vital role in shaping accountability within law-enforcement institutions. Although Kearns & Muir (2019), primarily focused on data-driven policing, his findings highlight that transparent data collection and internal reporting systems can provide valuable evidence for policy reforms, allowing police leaders to identify recurring issues and strengthen accountability mechanisms within their organizations.

Theoretical Framework

The framework is further supported by Procedural Justice Theory (Tyler, 2003), which posits that fair and respectful treatment by authorities enhances institutional legitimacy and voluntary compliance with the law. In policing, this means that when officers apply equal protection, use force proportionally, and uphold detainees' rights, citizens are more likely to perceive law enforcement as just and trustworthy. Conversely, violations of these principles undermine police legitimacy and foster community distrust (Sunshine & Tyler, 2003). This theory provides the behavioral and psychological foundation for understanding how human-rights awareness translates into rights-based law enforcement practices. Furthermore, Organizational Justice Theory Colquitt et al., (2015) complements this framework by highlighting that awareness and adherence to human rights within police institutions are strengthened when officers perceive fairness, accountability, and ethical leadership in their organization.

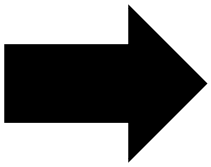
The theoretical framework combines the, Procedural Justice Theory, and Organizational Justice Theory to explain that the higher the level of human-rights awareness among police officers, the greater their compliance with the ten human-rights standards in practice. These frameworks collectively emphasize that awareness of equal protection, humane treatment, lawful arrest, and accountability are not merely theoretical ideals but operational necessities that define a professional, democratic, and rights-based police service.

Schematic Diagram

Independent Variables

Profile of the Respondents

- Age
- Gender
- Years of Service
- Rank



Dependent Variables

Assessing the Level of Human Rights Awareness and Understanding Among Police Officers: Implications for Right-Based Law Enforcement

- Equal Protection
- Respectful Treatment
- Use of Force
- Policing Non-Violent Assemblies
- Use of Lethal Force
- Arresting Persons on legal Grounds
- Detainee's Rights
- Humane Treatment of Detainees
- Refusal to Obey Unjust Orders
- Reporting Violations

Statement of the Problem

This study assessed the level of human rights awareness among police officers and its implications for rights-based law enforcement. Specifically, it sought to answer the following questions:

1. What is the Profile of the Respondents in terms of:

   1.1. Age;

   1.2. Gender;

   1.3. Years of Service; and

   1.4. Rank or Position?

2. What is the level of human rights awareness and understanding among police officers in terms of:

   2.1. Equal Protection;

   2.2. Respectful Treatment;

   2.3. Use of Force;

   2.4. Policing Non-Violent Assemblies;

   2.5. Use of Lethal Force;

   2.6. Arresting Persons on Legal Grounds;

   2.7. Detainees' Rights;

   2.8. Humane Treatment of Detainees;

   2.9. 2.9. Refusal to Obey Unjust Orders; and

2.10. Reporting Violations?

3. Is there a significant relationship between respondents profile and their level of human rights awareness among police officer?

4. Is there a significant differences and the level of human rights awareness among police when grouped according to their profile?

Hypothesis

Ho1: There is no significant relationship between the respondent's profile and their level of human rights awareness

Ho2: There is no significant difference in the level of human rights among police officers when group according to their profile

Scope and Limitations

This study focuses on assessing the Level of Human Rights Awareness among Police Officers: Implications for Rights-Based Law Enforcement. It primarily examines the level of knowledge, understanding, and perceptions of police officers regarding human rights and how these factors influence the performance of their official duties. The respondents of the study consist of police officers, and the research is conducted within the Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. A quantitative research method using survey questionnaires is employed as the main instrument for data collection.

The study is limited to police officers assigned to the Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen areas and relies on self-reported data, which may be subject to response bias. It also focuses only on selected aspects of human rights awareness and does not include other factors that may influence police behavior.

Definition of Terms

Age - The number of years a police officer has lived. It is used to determine whether awareness and understanding of human rights vary across different age groups.

Arresting Persons on Legal Grounds - Understanding that arrests should only be made when there is a lawful and valid reason in the context of policing.

Detainees' Rights - Awareness that individuals in custody must receive fair treatment, medical care, and protection from abuse.

Equal Protection - Awareness that police officers must ensure all individuals are treated fairly and equally under the law, regardless of their background, status, or identity, while performing law enforcement duties.

Gender - The identification of a police officer as male, female, or other. It is used to determine whether gender affects attitudes and practices related to human rights in policing.

Humane Treatment of Detainees - Understanding that detainees should be handled without cruelty or humiliation while under police custody.

Policing Non-Violent Assemblies - Knowledge that police must protect the right of citizens to peacefully assemble without unnecessary interference.

Rank - The official role or level of a police officer (e.g., patrol officer, sergeant, lieutenant). It is used to determine whether rank affects responsibility and exposure to human rights training.

Refusal to Obey Unjust Order - Knowledge that police officers must not follow orders that violate citizens' human rights.

Reporting Violations - Awareness that any unlawful or abusive acts by police officers should be reported to ensure accountability.

Respectful Treatment - Awareness that police officers should treat all citizens with dignity and respect during law enforcement activities.

Use of Force - Understanding that force should only be applied when necessary and in the least harmful way while performing policing duties.

Use of Lethal Force - Awareness that lethal force may only be used as a last resort to protect life or prevent serious harm during law enforcement operations.

Years of Service - The total time a police officer has worked in the police force. It is used to determine whether experience influences knowledge and application of human rights principles.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter discussed the research method, research design, research environment, research materials, the respondents' population, ethical standards, and the statistical tools used to analyze and interpret the data.

Research Design

This research will apply a descriptive-quantitative research design. A descriptive quantitative research design is a method used to systematically describe characteristics, behaviors, opinions, or perceptions of a specific population through numerical data. This design focuses on "what exists" rather than "why it exists," aiming to measure and summarize variables as they naturally occur without manipulating them. It allows researchers to present a factual and statistical account of a phenomenon Saunders et al., (2019).

It aims to assess the level of human rights awareness and understanding among police officers. The descriptive method will be used to determine and describe the existing conditions and characteristics of the respondents in terms of their awareness and understanding of human rights, while the quantitative approach will allow the researcher to gather numerical data that can be statistically analyzed. This design is appropriate for the study because it provides measurable information that can help identify trends, patterns, and relationships among the variables being studied, such as age, gender, rank, and years of service.

Research Materials and Methods

This Study uses a descriptive-quantitative research design. This study will use a researcher-made survey questionnaire as the main tool to collect data on the level of human rights awareness

and understanding among police officers. The questionnaire will use a four-point Likert scale with the choices: Strongly Agree, Agree, Disagree, and Strongly Disagree. Before it is used, the questionnaire will be checked and validated by experts to make sure the items are clear and reliable. After it is approved, the researchers will personally give the questionnaires to the selected respondents and collect them once completed. The data gathered will then be tallied and analyzed statistically to determine the overall results.

Research Environment, Population and Sample

Research Environment

The study will be conducted in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, three municipalities in Agusan Del Norte, Philippines, particularly among police stations under the Philippine National Police (PNP). The study was conducted specifically in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. This research environment is chosen because it provides access to active police officers who are directly involved in law enforcement and human rights–related activities.

The population will include all police officers in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, while the sample will consist of selected officers chosen through purposive sampling. The respondents will represent different ranks, years of service, age, and gender to obtain diverse perspectives on their level of human rights awareness and understanding.

The respondents of this study consist of police officers assigned to the selected areas, specifically in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. They were chosen as our participants because police officers serve as the primary implementers of law enforcement and are entrusted with upholding, protecting, and respecting human rights in the performance of their duties.

Population and Sample

Table 1. Respondents of the Study

LOCATION	Population	
	F	%
Buenavista	**20**	**28.2**
Nasipit	**33**	**46.5**
Carmen	**18**	**25.4**
Total	**71**	**100.0**

Research Data and Analysis Plan

The data for this study will be gathered from the responses of police officers to the administered survey questionnaire. The collected data will include their level of human rights awareness and understanding, along with their demographic profiles such as age, gender, rank, and years of service. After the data collection, the researchers will organize, tally, and tabulate all response. The data will then be analyzed using statistical tools such as frequency and percentage to describe the respondents' profiles, and weighted mean to determine their overall level of awareness and understanding of human rights. The results of the analysis will serve as the basis for identifying trends, patterns, or variations among respondents across different demographic characteristics.

The data will be analyzed with the use of an appropriate statistical method:

Frequency and Percentage. It will be use to present the distribution of respondents in terms of their demographic profile, such as age, gender, rank, and years of service.

Mean. It will be use to determine the level of human rights awareness among police officers based on their responses to the survey items. This helps determine whether their awareness is based on Likert-scale ratings.

Person Correlation. It will be use to determine if there is a significant relationship between the respondent's profile and the dependent variables Anova. It will be used to compare the human rights awareness of police officers based on different groups such as rank, gender, or age. It determines if there are significant differences in the level of human rights awareness among these groups.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards (A-M)

A. Protection of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This study ensures compliance with intellectual property rights by securing all research outputs, including surveys, reports, and data-gathering tools, under the protection of Philippine copyright law. All references and secondary materials utilized in the research were properly cited to uphold academic integrity and avoid plagiarism. As the study did not produce any new technology, process, or product that would require patent registration, and no exclusive logo, brand, or symbol was created, trademark application was deemed unnecessary.

B. Informed Consent

Ensured that all participants were fully informed about the purpose, procedures, potential risks, and benefits of the research before taking part. Written consent was secured from all respondents to confirm their voluntary participation and understanding of their rights throughout the study. Since the research did not involve any experiments on animals or living organisms, ethical approval for such trials was not required.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

This study strictly adhered to data privacy and confidentiality standards. All personal and sensitive information collected from participants was treated with utmost confidentiality and used solely for research purposes. Participant identities were anonymized to protect their privacy, and the collected data were securely stored in password-protected files accessible only to the researchers. No data was shared with third parties without the participants' explicit consent, ensuring full compliance with the Data Privacy Act of 2012.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

This study ensured that participation was entirely voluntary. All respondents were clearly informed about the purpose of the study and their right to withdraw at any stage without facing any negative consequences. Their decision to participate was based on free will, without any form of pressure or coercion. Since the research did not involve the use of animals or living organisms, ethical standards related to animal testing were not applicable.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

This study took necessary steps to minimize any possible harm to participants. The questions were carefully designed to avoid causing physical, psychological, or emotional distress, and participation was conducted in a respectful and non-intrusive manner. Respondents were assured that they could skip any questions that made them uncomfortable and withdraw at any time without penalty. Since the study did not involve animals or living organisms, ethical guidelines concerning animal welfare were not applicable.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

This study was conducted with the principle of beneficence, aiming to provide valuable insights that can help improve the implementation and effectiveness of the BFP's modernization initiatives. The findings are expected to contribute positively to the academic community by enriching existing

literature on public service modernization and to society by supporting better strategies for fire safety and volunteer engagement. Participants may request access to the study's results, ensuring transparency and shared learning from the research outcomes.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

This study ensured justice and fairness in participant selection. Respondents were chosen based on clear and transparent inclusion criteria relevant to the research objectives, focusing on BFP personnel and fire volunteers directly involved in or affected by the modernization program. Participation was open to individuals regardless of rank, gender, age, or background, ensuring equal opportunity and the avoidance of any form of discrimination. Since the study did not involve animal trials, the criteria related to animal selection were not applicable.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

This study ensured data integrity and accuracy by using standardized methods in data collection and analysis. Established research instruments and statistical tools were applied to maintain consistency, reliability, and validity of the results. All potential biases, errors, and limitations encountered during the study were carefully identified and documented to provide a transparent and credible representation of the findings.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

This study upholds transparency and honesty in reporting all research findings. The results were presented accurately, without fabrication, alteration, or misrepresentation of data. All copyrighted and patented materials, including references, instruments, and secondary sources used in the study, were properly cited and acknowledged to maintain academic integrity and uphold ethical research standards.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

This study did not involve the use of any patented technologies, processes, or products requiring clearance from patent holders. However, copyrighted materials such as literature, references, and statistical software were properly cited and used in accordance with copyright laws. Appropriate permissions and acknowledgments were ensured to respect intellectual property rights and maintain ethical research practices.

K. Considerations for Human Subjects

This study involved only human participants who were fully informed about the purpose, procedures, potential risks, and benefits of their participation before giving their consent. Ethical standards were strictly followed to ensure their safety, comfort, and voluntary involvement throughout the study. Since the research did not include any animal trials, ethical clearance and guidelines related to animal use were not applicable.

M. Responsible Use of AI and Other Technologies

This study involved only human participants who were fully informed about the purpose, procedures, potential risks, and benefits of their participation before giving their consent. Ethical standards were strictly followed to ensure their safety, comfort, and voluntary involvement throughout the study. Since the research did not include any animal trials, ethical clearance and guidelines related to animal use were not applicable.

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